CHAPTER 1:

THE MANY ARMORS OF IRONMAN

The most important thing about *Iron Man* is obviously the special effects, right? The sizzle of the repulsor rays as they lance through the stillness of the air, the shooosh of his contrail as he leaves fighter jets in his supersonic dust, the raw power of his ultra-modern tech... the glitz, right? Well, in a movie like *Iron Man*, all that stuff is indeed important to get right. But achieving the authenticity and wow of the visual effects is all part of a process, one the film's crew knew full well in advance had a more down-to-earth mandate: Before they put the armor outside the man, they must find the heart inside the man.

The most important component a movie like *Iron Man* has to have is something that can't be conjured up on a design table: It's got to have heart. As soon as Jon Favreau signed on to helm Marvel's first self-financed blockbuster film, a script began development that went straight for Tony Stark's humanity. Delving deep into Iron Man's rich history with the film's producers, Favreau fleshed out the character motivations that would form the basis of his art team's approach to design.

Now that the unbelievable success of *Iron Man* is behind us – and with full awareness that it has turned into a franchise-worthy phenomenon – *The Art of Iron Man* traces the many elements of the film's design process. After the movie's emotional core was figured out, it was left to the film's art crew to start building the armor from the ground up. In this chapter, you'll see the work of the most talented conceptual artists in the business as they develop the many armors of Iron Man. Along the way, you'll witness the evolution of the armor – from concept design to sketches to 3D modeling to the final construction of the suit – more as a process of human refinement than anything else. Reading between the lines of the many fine artists who worked on this suit of armor, you will hear the echoes of Favreau's mission statement: "Tony Stark has a heart. Now let's go build something around it!"

